

TRENCH WARFARE



Spending nearly two weeks—from June 1 to June 12, 1864—in flat open fields, swept by artillery and sniper fire, soldiers of both armies dug a complex maze of trenches around the road junction at Cold Harbor. Behind their parapets, troops constructed bombproof shelters to sleep in and excavated holes to build fires. They filled gabions (open-ended wickerwork cages) with dirt for shock absorption—a technique they would use again at Petersburg (pictured). Rain turned the trenches into rivers, and in the sun, blankets stretched between bayoneted rifles screened the men.